

Week 6: The Colored Volunteers/Bonnet Brigades

Questions

1. Evaluate the roles and the effects of women in and on the Civil War.
2. How important was emancipation to the Northern victory?
3. Does "Give Us a Flag" sum up the entirety of the African-American experience during the Civil War?

Key Terms

- Robert Gould Shaw
- Home Front
- Southern Refugees
- James Henry Gooding

Black Volunteers by State

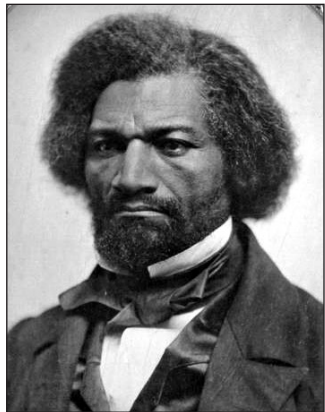
Connecticut: 1,764
Colorado Territory: 95
Delaware: 954
District of Columbia: 3,269
Illinois: 1,811
Indiana: 1,597
Iowa: 440
Kansas: 2,080
Kentucky: 23,703
Maine: 104
Maryland: 8,718
Massachusetts: 3,966
Michigan: 1,387
Minnesota: 104
Missouri: 8,344
New Hampshire: 125
New Jersey: 1,185
New York: 4,125
Ohio: 5,092
Pennsylvania: 8,612
Rhode Island: 1,837
Vermont: 120
West Virginia: 196
Wisconsin: 155
Total, North: 79,283

Alabama: 4,969
Arkansas: 5,526
Florida: 1,044
Georgia: 3,486
Louisiana: 24,502
Mississippi: 17,869
North Carolina: 5,035
South Carolina: 5,462
Tennessee: 20,133
Texas: 47
Virginia: 5,723
Total, South: 93,796

At large: 733
Not accounted for: 5,083

Total, Overall: 178,895

An American Epic: The 54th Massachusetts Infantry Regiment



From Fort Sumter onward, Frederick Douglass (left) campaigned ceaselessly for black recruitment. "The Negro is the key to the situation," he said, "the pivot upon which the whole rebellion turns...This war, disguise it as they may, is virtually nothing more or less than perpetual slavery against universal freedom."

Massachusetts governor John A. Andrew (center) was an enthusiastic abolitionist and lobbied President Lincoln tirelessly to enlist black troops into the Union Armies.

Robert Gould Shaw (right) was the scion of a prominent Massachusetts abolitionist family, and was serving in the 2nd Massachusetts when plans for the 54th Massachusetts began to be made. After initial reluctance, he agreed to accept a commission as the unit's colonel.

Recruiting the 54th

This year has brought about many changes that at the beginning would have been thought impossible. The close of the year finds me a soldier for the cause of my race. May God bless the cause.

- Christian Fleetwood, 1863

NOW IN CAMP AT READVILLE!

54th REGIMENT!

MASS VOLUNTEERS, composed of men of

AFRICAN DESCENT

COL. ROBERT G. SHAW.

Colored Men. Rally 'Round the Flag of Freedom!

BOUNTY \$100!

AT THE EXPIRATION OF THE TERM OF SERVICE.

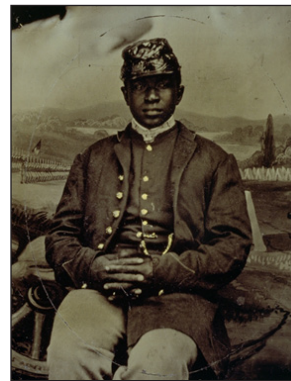
Pay, \$13 a Month!

Good Food & Clothing!

State Aid to Families!

RECRUITING OFFICE.

COR. CAMBRIDGE & NORTH RUSSELL STS., BOSTON.



The 54th Massachusetts was drawn primarily from the free African-American population of the North. Early enlistees included Pvt. Abraham Brown (top left), Sgt. Henry Stewart (bottom left), Sgt. Major Lewis Douglass (top right), and Pvt. (later 1st Lt.) Peter Vogelsang. Douglass was one of two sons of Frederick Douglass to serve in the unit, while Vogelsang was one of the first black officers in the army.

Give Us a Flag



*Oh, Fremont he told them when the war it first begun
How to save the Union and the way it should be done
But old Kentucky swore so hard and Abe he had his fears
Till every hope was lost but the colored volunteers*

*McClellan went to Richmond with 200,000 brave
He said, 'keep back the niggers,' and the Union I will save"
Little Mac he had his way, still the Union is in tears
NOW they call for the help of the colored volunteers*

*Oh, give us a flag, all free without a slave
We'll fight to defend it as our fathers did so brave
The gallant Comp'ny 'A' will make the Rebels dance
And we'll stand by the Union if we only have a chance*

*Old Jeff says he'll hang us if we dare to meet him armed
A very big thing, but we are not at all alarmed
For he first has got to catch us before the way is clear
That is "what's the matter" with the colored volunteer*

*So rally, boys, rally, let us never mind the past
We had a hard road to travel, but our day is coming fast
For God is for the right, and we have no need to fear
The Union must be saved by the colored volunteer*

- "Give Us a Flag," written by an anonymous member of the 54th Massachusetts, 1863

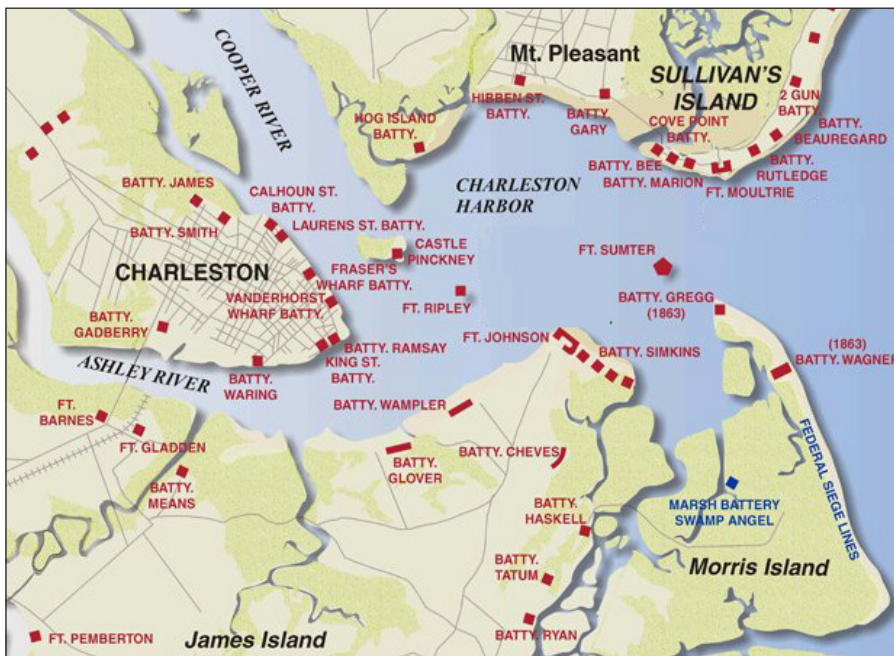
The original members of the 54th Massachusetts (top) did much of their training at Fort Lincoln, Va., where they were photographed.

One of the key rites of passage for a Civil War unit was the receipt of their flag. It was a sign that their community and their government deemed them ready to fight, as the anonymous writer of "Give Us a Flag" knew well. The men 54th Massachusetts eventually got their flags, including this one, which belonged to the unit's Company A (center).

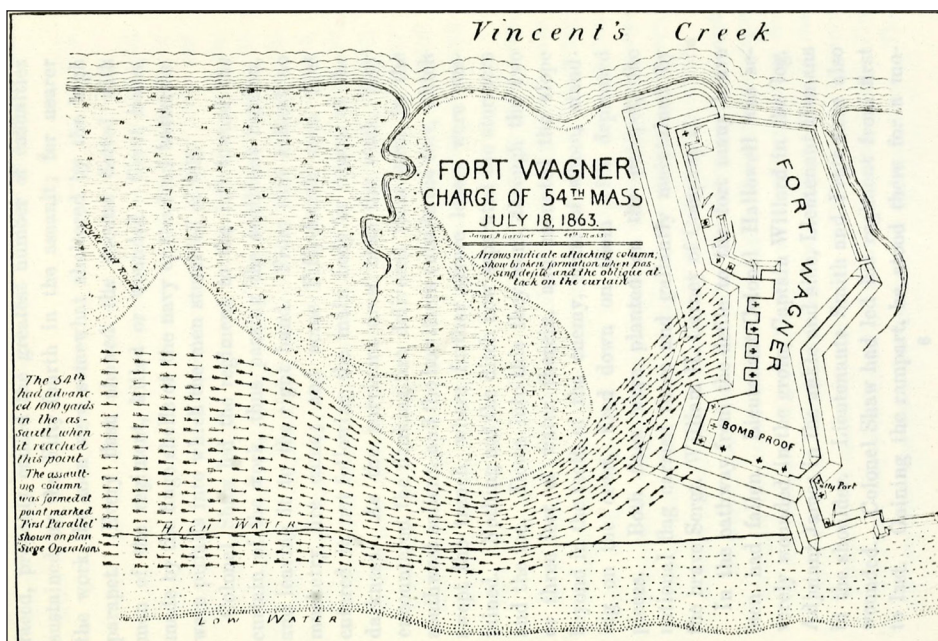
Another key rite of passage for soldiers during the Civil War was their first experience in battle—"Seeing the elephant," as it was known. Despite the fact that the 54th Massachusetts had completed its training and had received its flags, Union authorities seemingly had no intention of using the unit in combat, and instead assigned the men to labor details. Col. Shaw and other prominent Northerners—including Gov. Andrew—protested this, and the unit was eventually given responsibility for leading a dangerous charge on Fort Wagner, which guards the harbor of Charleston, SC.

*Will the slave fight? If any man asks you, tell him 'No.'
But if anyone asks you, 'Will a Negro fight?', tell him
'Yes.'*

- Wendell Phillips, 1863



The Battle of Fort Wagner: July 18, 1863



On July 18, just three days after the New York City draft riots ended, 600 men of the 54th Massachusetts assaulted Fort Wagner, South Carolina, part of a thwarted campaign to take Charleston (top).

When the color bearer fell and the order to withdraw was given, Sgt. William Carney seized the colors and made it back to his lines despite bullets in the head, chest, right arm and leg (bottom left). He was the first of 23 blacks to win the Congressional Medal of Honor during the war, although he had to wait 37 years to receive it.

"It is not too much to say that if this Massachusetts 54th had faltered when its trial came," reported the *New York Tribune*, "two hundred thousand troops for whom it was a pioneer would never have put into the field...But it did not falter. It made Fort Wagner such a name for the colored people as Bunker Hill has been for ninety years to the white Yankees."

Colonel Robert Gould Shaw, the Boston abolitionists' son who commanded the 54th Massachusetts, was among the dead, killed as he charged the fort's parapet with this men (center). Confederates stripped his body, then threw it into a mass grave with the bodies of his men. Shaw's grieving father spoke to the press:

The poor, benighted wretches thought they were heaping indignities upon his dead body, but the act recoils upon them...They buried him with his brave, devoted followers who fell dead over him and around him...We can imagine no holier place than that in which he is...nor wish him better company--what a bodyguard he has!



List of the Names of the Enlisted men of the 54th Regiment Mass. Who Missing after the assault on Ft. Wagner July 18th 1863

No	Names	Rank	No	Names	Rank
1	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	1	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant
2	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	2	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant
3	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	3	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant
4	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	4	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant
5	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	5	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant
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100	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant	100	Abraham Lincoln	Sergeant

The 54th Massachusetts' charge not only left Shaw dead, but also inflicted horrific casualties on the unit as a whole, as the list compiled after the battle (bottom right) illustrates. More than 40% of the men did not return. Though they failed to take the Fort, they nonetheless did what they had set out to do—prove that African-American soldiers would, indeed, fight.

After Fort Wagner



After Fort Wagner, Shaw and the 54th Massachusetts were lauded as heroes and were celebrated for many years, particularly in New England and in the African-American community. In 1897, they were honored with a large Augustus Saint-Gaudens bas-relief sculpture in Boston (top). In the 20th century, however, the unit began to fade into obscurity. They were finally “rescued” by historians in 1960s, and then by Hollywood filmmakers in 1989, with the release of *Glory*. The movie features Morgan Freeman as the fictional John Rawlins (bottom left), and Matthew Broderick as Robert Gould Shaw (bottom right).